defense and development priorities. India, on its part, had less expectations of US assistance.

Overall, the two countries had fewer expectations of each other, and American officials tried to keep them low. Indian policymakers realized that they no longer had much traction in Washington since American policymakers no longer felt the need to build India up as a contrast to China. Furthermore, they believed that, even if relations improved, economic assistance would remain limited because of legislative and budgetary limits in the US.[27] This acknowledgment and the decrease in aid had the added benefit of Indian policymakers feeling less of a need to balance aid acceptance with anti-American rhetoric to emphasize their independence. During the emergency, Gandhi did continue to criticize "general external forces" for political purposes, but privately her government continued to seek to improve US-India relations.[28] There was also some easing of Indian concerns about the US "refusal to endorse … or to enhance" the country's status as a regional power or global player.[29] US officials publicly and privately increasingly acknowledged India as at least the "strongest power on the subcontinent."[30]

Delhi also believed that Washington would worry less about India-Soviet relations. It had no desire to jettison its relationship with Moscow—after all it was the bird in hand, and officials believed that the India-Soviet relationship helped restrain China.[31] Nonetheless, the Indian government moved to correct its overdependence. Moreover, to ensure that US policymakers did not think India had tilted entirely toward Moscow, Indian officials went out of their way to assert that this was not the case. American officials, in turn, noted that, with the developing US-Soviet détente and their belief that India would remain nonaligned, they were less concerned about India-Soviet relations. On a trip to India, Kissinger even acknowledged publicly that the US accepted Indian nonalignment.[32]

As for Pakistan—another irritant in the US-India relationship—Delhi tried to work through its problems with that country, and policymakers came to believe that the US was indeed urging Islamabad to settle its problems with Bangladesh and India.[33] American officials did encourage Pakistan to persist with the Shimla peace process and made clear to Pakistani president Zulfiqar Ali Bhutto that Chinese intervention in the subcontinent on Pakistan's behalf would be counterproductive.[34] When it